

Originations and Developments of Modern Chinese Poetry

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Photo: Clément Morin

Han Kang
Nobel Prize in Literature 2024

“For her intense poetic prose that confronts historical traumas and exposes the fragility of human life.”

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If you had paid attention to the award ceremony of the Nobel Prize back in 2024, last year, you may notice that the Nobel Prize in Literature was given to South Korean woman writer, Han Kang, which is for her intense poetic prose that confronts historical traumas and exposes the fragility of human life, which was mainly discussed in her novel *Human Acts*, published in 2014. In the novel, the main plot follows with the Gwangju Uprising movement started at May 1980 by students and civilians, mainly, which aimed to fight against the military regime (/reɪ'ʒi:m/) of Chun Doo-hwan, that ended up with violence and bleedings. Which is discussed here as the “historical traumas” in the praise words for the awardee. But we are not going to discuss this event mainly, but to pay attention to the praise words themselves as “poetic” here appears as adjective form to decorate the “prose” behind it. The characteristic of poem is used here to describe the style of prose, which is a totally different writing style, which is quite interesting. And in recent years, probably in this decade, the Nobel Prize committee seems pretty enchanting to the word “poetic” and poets as well. You know, just Han Kang herself writes some poems in her daily life. Such attention to poet makes them feel extremely interested to make poet as a Nobel Prize awardee, and if they cannot find a real poet, they’ll make one.



Photo: William Claxton

American Balladeer
Bob Dylan

Nobel Prize in Literature 2016

“For having created new poetic expressions
within the great American song tradition.”

2

Right around 2016, an American guy was probably playing his guitar when he got a phone call which the caller identified themselves as the Nobel Prize committee. Hey, Bob, we announced you as a poet by ourselves and you come to get the award for Nobel Prize in Literature this year. And the guy said, oh, fraudulence, and put it down. Anyway, in 2016, this guy, our Bob, an American balladeer was given the Nobel Prize in Literature in 2016 for have created new poetic expressions within the great American song tradition. “Poetic”, the word, is mentioned again here. So, “poetic” now is used to describe a poem-like aspects, which can be used in different types of passages, novels, proses... or maybe a type of emotion, which is used to describe a writing style especially in some specific writers, like SHEN Congwen, which reveals an imagination nostalgia through a poetic lyricism (/ˈlɪrɪsɪzəm/). Back to poetry itself, it is a transcultural literacy style, not like novels, which request a local collective recognition to read, poetry writing can have empathy worldwide. Developing under different cultural backgrounds but successfully reaches a sense of emotional agreement and acknowledgement, poetry has penetrated through the gap among geographical barriers and made its path into the inner side of the humanity which I called the primitive emotionality. Speak of poetry, and as its cultural meanings, it’s inevitable to make a glance of the world of Chinese Literature for its long-lasting duration and dynamic changes together with its unique stability.

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So, welcome everyone, this is XIANG Hanyi, from now on, we're gonna dive deeper into the world of Literature and especially on the originations and developments of modern Chinese Poetry.

Why P.O.E.M.S.?

POETRY

- 志也。从言寺聲。詁，古文詩省。書之切。
——《說文解字》*Shuo Wen Jie Zi*
- *Shi* means *Zhi*. Its radical follows by *Yan* (speaking) with *Si* (temple) as its phonetic compound. “詁” is a simplified version for “詩” in classical text, and its pronunciation origins from “書” (*Shu*).



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Before talking about our protagonist, I wanna talk about the poetry, poems as a whole. Poetry, by definition, that I find it in *Shuo Wen Jie Zi*, that is a Chinese dictionary showing the definition of each single character. The first part shows the meaning of the word, while the second shows its structure and origination. While the third just showing a complicated version of the word. The last shows how to pronounce this word. As I translate it below, *Shi* means *Zhi*, while the meaning of *Zhi* will be clarified later. Its radical..., pronunciation origins from *Shu*, which means the book in English.

Why P.O.E.M.S.?

- *Si* (寺)

Sounds from the temple/palace...

A sense of **isolation**.

- *Zhi* (志)

「志，意也。」

Zhi is a sensation.

Poetry is a **feeling** and **expressionism**.

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From the structure of Shi, it can be noticed that besides the left part, which is speaking (*Yan*), the right part Si typically means the temple in English but can also be translated as the palace where the emperor lived back in ancient China. But considering both meanings, we can feel a sense of isolation through the building material of the word Shi. Either the temple, or the palace is set away from civilians, such isolation can be noticed through the at-a-glance figure of poems. When writing or reading poems, we always find out the symbolic expression of words in them. In other word, words we used in daily life have been extended into various dimensions to interpret different meanings. Such extension creates an isolation set based on the disorder between the signifier and the signified. Right, say the wind simply means the flowing of air in our physical world but can be whispered as people's voice during some context in specific poems and can be changed into different meanings or expression in different contexts as well. On the other hand, Zhi, which I mentioned earlier as the meaning of Shi, is a sensation itself. Also, according to *Shuo Wen Jie Zi*. Zhi is a feeling, and poetry is a collection of words expressing feelings. Therefore, poetry can be simply considered as a feeling itself as an expressionism.

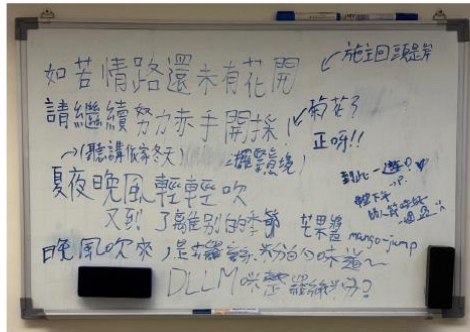
Why P.O.E.M.S.?

- Literature is a combination and reflection of humanity.
- Poetry
Emotional/Purified
Highly Symbolized/Concise
Less politicalized
- To read poems, we are facing the will directly.

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So, such unique identity makes poetry nearly a most purified form of Literature. As Literature, we always write things and stories around us and sometimes trying to think deeper into the characteristics of human nature, thus it can be considered as a combination and reflection of humanity. For poetry, it's highly emotional, as mentioned, itself as an expression of feelings, and purified as well since it's less politicalized. For normal literacy works, it is usually compelled to follow the ideology in certain region or for certain aspects. However, again, mainly due to isolation, poetry itself derives a blank within interpretations thus drags it away from policies much further than normal writings. It's also highly symbolized, concise due to the use of symbolic expressions of words, also mentioned earlier. So, talking about poetry, we are trying to trace back to the primitive condition of human thoughts and impulsions. To read poems, we're facing the will directly.

Any Daily Poems?



In Chih Hsing Hall



At the Science Center

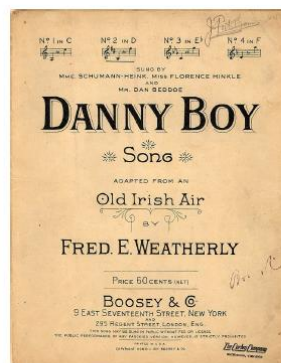
7

After a long academic deconstruction of the word “Poetry”, poetry itself is not that far away from our lives. Maybe you guys can come up some poems you see in your everyday life?

Here I take two pictures. One is the words by anonymous in Chih Hsing Hall in our NA college. In Literature analysis, it can be considered as a very direct expression of grafting personal feelings onto natural representations. Btw, if this gets a copyright issue, should let me know. Anyway, and the other is taken at the Science Center, which is excerpt copy of a poem by YU Jian in 1994.

Any Daily Poems?

- Folk/Lyrics



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Besides, the lyrics of folk music can also be seen as a type of poetry that shows a poetic expression. They're telling stories that basically happened between folks or civilians,

expressing emotions in the most direct way, or some of them get some symbolic words using, so why not?

Danny Boy – Frederic E. Weatherly, 1913

Oh, Danny boy, the pipes, the pipes are calling	But when ye come, and all the flowers are dying,
From glen to glen, and down the mountain side.	If I am dead, as dead I well may be,
The summer's gone, and all the roses falling,	Ye'll come and find and place where I am lying,
It's you, it's you must go and I must bide.	And kneel and say an Avé there for me.
But come ye back when summer's in the meadow,	And I shall hear, though soft you tread above me,
Or when the valley's hushed and white with snow,	And all my grave will warmer, sweeter be,
It's I'll be here in sunshine or in shadow,	For you will bend and tell me that you love me,
Oh, Danny boy, Oh Danny boy, I love you so!	And I shall sleep in peace until you come to me!

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Let's first take a look at a classic folk in Ireland, *Danny Boy*, written in 1913. It's telling a story about an elder father talking to his son who was sending to the battlefield, saying his oncoming death and love towards the son.

Grandmother's Penghu Bay (*Excerpt*)(外婆的澎湖灣) – PENG Anbang, 1979

Evening wind gently brushes Penghu Bay; whites waves pursue sandy shore.
There is no coconut grove connecting setting sun; only piece of blue blue sea.
Sitting on the low wall in front of the front door, over and over again I reminisce:
It was also at evening on the sandy shore, there were two and a half pairs' footprints.

That was grandmother holding a cane gently carrying me on the arm.
We stepped on the thin dusk and walked toward the remaining sunshine at the warm,
warm Penghu Bay.
One footprint was a string of laughing words; we idled away a lot of time.
Till the color of night swallowed us on our way of returning home road.

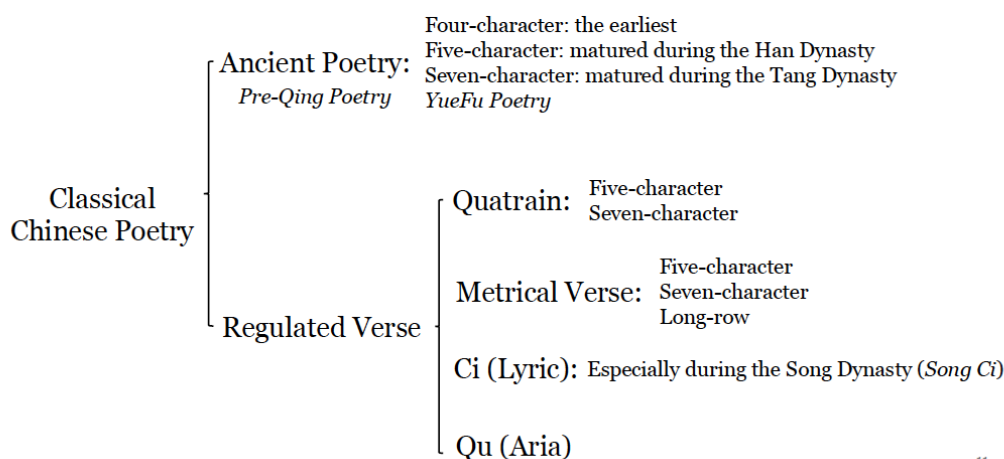
Translated by Han Keat LIM

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The next is an also a classic folk, or I would say a milestone for Chinese modern folk, *Grandmother's Penghu Bay*, which is presented by PENG Anbang in 1979. If we just focus on the translation version of *Grandmother's Penghu Bay*, we can find out some similar points between these two lyrics that make them much alike. One of the most obvious characteristics is the changes in the order of writing. "And all my grave will warmer, sweeter

be” with “over and over again I reminisce (/ˌremɪˈnɪs/)”. Despite the English characteristic introduced by translation; the stories they’re telling are also much alike. Both of them are talking about interfamilial relationship which leads to a feeling of recalling. We can simply say that *Grandmother’s Penghu Bay* can be described in some aspects as a Chinese version of *Danny Boy*. If we hide the nationality out, it’s really hard to distinguish between them. So, are Contemporary or just Modern Chinese poetry really such alike to that in Western? It’s quite hard to bump into conclusion. The historical path for the development of Chinese poetry should be introduced then.

Classical Chinese Poetry



This is a basic category for classical Chinese poetry, which is divided into basically two types, and they’re actually time related. The upper one Ancient Poetry appears ahead of the lower one, Regulated Verse. The Ancient Poetry is also known as the Pre-Qing Poetry, where Qing is a dynasty in ancient China. It’s divided into another 4 smaller parts, as listed: the four-character one, the five-character one, the seven-character one and the Yuefu poetry. The number of characters here characterize each type of poetry. Say, for the five-character one, it means that each line of poem, there’s only five characters. During the composition, rhymes (/raɪmz/) aren’t a strict requirement. There’s a type of ancient poetry mentioned here that is YueFu poetry which consists the poems collected from the civilians around the Han dynasty for the prior ones, which also asks for a low restriction of writing. However, as the era of Regulated verse comes, the composition became much fugue-like, which simply means a creation with restrictions. Here, it’s mainly divided into four types, Quatrain, Metrical Verse, Lyric, and Aria. Quatrain, in Chinese, 絕句, asks for a maximum

lines of poems to 4. The characters here is the same as the ancient poetry mentioned earlier. For the Metrical Verse, in Chinese, 律詩, has a requirement of mainly 8 lines in one poem, and can be considered as the most rhymed type of poetry. Again, the number of characters in a single line is still strictly fixed. Here, the Long-row one shows a special type of Metrical Verse with a longer lines in poem larger than 8. Lyric is composed within a same pattern of words or rhymes under a same title. Here, the title of lyric characterizes the composition. For Aria, it then becomes much related to music during performing. But quite an interesting part in this sheet is that from the Ancient Poetry to the Regulated Verse, the requirements that needed to be met passed down from one to the other, eventually leading to a much “stable” creation pattern.

Blue Collar /Zi Jin (子衿) – *Book of Odes*

O you, with the blue collar, prolonged is the anxiety of my heart.
Although I do not go [to you], why do you not continue your messages [to me]?
O you with the blue [strings to your] girdle-gems, long, long do I think of you.
Although I do not go [to you], why do you not come [to me]?
How volatile are you and dissipated, by the look-out tower on the wall!
One day without the sight of you, is like three months.

Translate by James Legge

青青子衿，悠悠我心。縱我不往，子寧不嗣音？
青青子佩，悠悠我思。縱我不往，子寧不來？
挑兮達兮，在城闕兮。一日不見，如三月兮！

——《詩經》

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Let's take a look at one of the poems in the collection call *Book of Odes, Blue Collar*, in Chinese, 子衿. This collection can be seen as the earliest collection of Chinese poetry that originated from the civilians. This one is translated from famous sinologist James Legge. You can easily notice the characteristic for Ancient Poetry here. The lines are not quite restricted and with a four-character in each line. When reading it, the rhythm is not that fluctuant and the story telling is simply a feeling of missing to a young woman by a young man. The most direct feeling is really similar to while reading an ancient text. In the English version, we can find a logic in writing where the description of the young woman is shown first and latter talked about the missing from the young man, pretty like an unrequited love. However, the emotion it expressed is very engaging, the words mainly bumped out directly without any adornment. A lot of repetitions and spoken auxiliaries (/ɔ:g'zɪləris/) are used

here, and the punctuations are quite various which also improve the expression of emotions from the speaker. We can picture vividly that a young man singing along the mountainside or by the meadow to express his missing and love to the young woman in his heart.

Mooring on River Qinhuai (泊秦淮) – DU Mu

Cold water veiled in mist and shores steeped in moonlight,
I moor on River Qinhuai near wineshops at night,
Where songgirls knowing not the grief of conquered land
Are singing songs composed by a captive ruler's hand.

Translate by X. Y. Z.

煙籠寒水月籠沙，
夜泊秦淮近酒家。
商女不知亡國恨，
隔江猶唱後庭花。

——〈泊秦淮〉杜牧（唐）

13

Here, as time passes, we entered the age of Quatrain. The *Mooring on River Qinhuai*, composed by DU Mu during the Tang Dynasty is a classic and typical example for this type. In the English translation, it depicts the poetry style very clearly. We can see the ending word of each line, “moonlight”, “night”, and “land”, “hand”. In Chinese, “沙”, “家”, and “花”. They’re all in rhyme, which makes a sense of unity in the poem. During the composition, we can find some traces of symbolic words. If the blue collar before is mainly an ornament for girls, here, in Chinese “後庭花”, which supposed to be a Palace music, but the usage here emphasize the tension between the failure of war of the conquered land to the joy and pleasant come from the singing songgirls. Moreover, we can find the render of a depressing and down phenomenon through the first two lines. The mood of the whole poem is be made and carried along the whole. Right, it can be noticed that the development of classical Chinese Poetry is pretty mature, and if you put modern Chinese Poetry together with the classical ones, you’ll distinguish them easily, right? So, there must be a big transformation to fulfill that large gap between these two, and we’ll soon figure out their motive to so.

About Modernization

Some Modest Proposals for the Reform of Literature

(文學改良芻議) HU Shih, 1917



The idea of *NEW*.

- self-classified
- in contrast to the *OLD*
- self-classicized
- exclusivity

14

The May-forth New Cultural Movement is a famous cultural revolution in the history of modern China. *Diary of a Madman*, in Chinese, 狂人日記, is the first novel written vernacular Chinese and was published in 1918. This can be seen as the first and the one of the most influential results of this movement. But before that, in the year 1917, HU Shih, one of our leaders in this movement published an essay which set a milestone for the start of the revolution, that is *Some Modest Proposals for the Reform of Literature*, 文學改良芻議, in Chinese. Interestingly, this essay was published using classical Chinese, but still in it, HU proposed a new path regarding the Chinese Literature. He suggested the usage of vernacular Chinese (“白話文”) and distinguish themselves as the new paragon for Chinese Literature. In saying of paragon, I mean there’s a value-added intention here established by Hu Shih to his NEW Literature, which made his new Literature in a self-classified form. In saying of the New, there’s a contrast towards the Old, which here probably means the classical one. Thus, for him, it’s reasonable to make a connection between the usage of vernacular Chinese and the GOOD value. He actually established a system of theory in creation and criticism of the new Literature, thus make itself isolate from the classical one. There are actually lots of books in classical Chinese saying the way of writing or the definition of better writings, from now, HU just came up with a totally new way of all such things, making his revolution exclusive. So, indeed, poetry also needs a reform in its style. I would say such reform contains the need requests from its contemporaneity but turns out to result in a sense of cosmopolitanism (/ˌkɑːzməˈpɑːlɪtənɪzəm/).

The Butterflies (兩隻蝴蝶) – HU Shih, 1916

Two yellow butterflies

In pair fly to the skies;

I don't know why

One suddenly returns

Leaving the other one

Lonely and pitiful.

It too has no heart to fly into the skies,

For heaven is too lonely a place.

兩隻黃蝴蝶，雙雙飛上天。

不知為什麼，一隻忽飛遠。

剩下那一隻，孤單怪可憐。

也無心上天，天上太孤單。

——〈兩隻蝴蝶〉胡適（民）

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Before that, let's have a look of one poem from HU Shih, *The Butterflies*, written in 1916. At-a-glance figure, it's quite alike to what we've seen just now, but a vernacular version. I mean, there's absolutely no things need to be analyzed, pretty not the kind of modern Chinese poetry that we're finding. We can still see the influence origins from the classical poetry. The pattern is quite restricted as a five-character Metrical Verse, I am not denying his innovation but due to the direct spelling of vernacular Chinese, the poem as a whole seems a little too "simple". However, as the New Cultural Movement gets its idea very much from abroad, why not turn our focus to the scholars that are actually in foreign regions.

German Romanticism

Emotionalism (主情主義): creation and synthesizing through emotions with the abandon of rational thinking

Nature: praise for nature

Pantheism (泛神論): ignorance of God/emphasizes on the expression of I (I = God)

A combination of the cosmos and the I with a dynamic and interactive melody, a sense of motion.

16

Firstly, about GUO Moruo, as a student studied in Japan, he could get a lot of influences

from Europe, especially from Germany. We may take a look at his writing strategy in comparisons with the German Romanticism. In German Romanticism, it emphasizes on three parts: emotionalism, nature, and pantheism (/ˈpænθiɪzəm/). Emotionalism simply means the creation and synthesizing through emotions with the abandon of rational thinking, while the saying of nature can be considered as the praise for nature. What is the most important will be the pantheism, as the ignorance of God, and the focus of the expression of I as the God. Due to a great empathy to the German philosopher Goethe, GUO's writing is quite following such pattern we've just mentioned in German Romanticism. During his writing, there's a combination of the cosmos and the I with a dynamic and interactive melody, that shows a sense of motion. Thus, when reading his poems, we'll find a sense of powerful and active interactions within the inner of the poet.

“I” as Heroism



“I” is God, and every nature is an expression of ‘I’.”

「我即是神，一切自然都是自我的表現。」
——〈《少年維特之煩惱》序引〉，郭沫若

17

Just as he wrote in the prologue his translation of Goethe's work *The Sorrows of Young Werther*, “I” is God, and every nature is an expression of ‘I’.” which turns “I” into a nearly hero like status.

The Sky Dog (天狗)

– GUO Moruo, 1920

Ya, I am a sky dog!
I have swallowed the moon,
I have swallowed the sun.
I have swallowed all the planets,
I have swallowed the entire universe.
I am I!

I am the light of the moon,
I am the light of the sun.
I am the light of all the plants,
I am the light of *X-ray*,
I am the total *energy* of the entire universe.

I am flying,
I am screaming,
I am burning,
I am burning like a fierce fire!
I am screening like the mighty ocean!
I am running like electricity!
I am running,
I am running,
I tear my skin,
I eat my flesh,
I chew my heart,
I am running on my nerves,
I am running on my spines,
I am running in my brain.

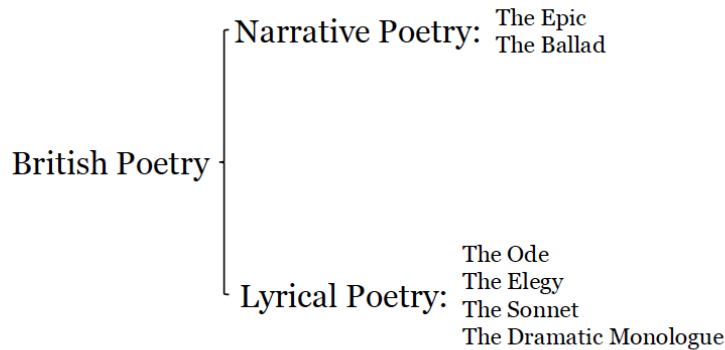
I am I!
The I of I is about to explode!

18

In his famous poem *The Sky Dog* (天狗), written in 1920, we can feel such nearly explosive emotion from him. One to be noticed, here, *X-ray* and *energy* are written in English originally. We can also find words like “electricity”, “nerve”, “spine”, “brain”, which all show a symbol of modernization, both in physics and medicine. In the first verse, we can pay attention to what “I” am doing, swallowing the moon, the sun, the planets, and the entire cosmos. It definitely shows a transition between his pantheism and the entire universe. What an “I”, isn’t it. A very giant figure of the poet “I” is shown throughout the whole text. This can also be shown through the pattern and repetition of “I”, leading to a high sense of speeding which results in the explosive of emotion.

Later, or during nearly the same time period, on the other opposite shore from Japan, one of the greatest genius for Chinese Poetry XU Zhimo had published his most famous *Second Farewell to Cambridge*, which is written in 1928. But before that, let’s take a look at the cultural influences behind him.

British Poetry



19

British poetry also has a long history and is mainly divided into two parts: narrative and lyrical. The first one tells stories more while the latter expresses more in emotion. For the narrative type, it's divided into 2 smaller types: epic and ballad. For ballad, we're quite familiar, just like our folk song contemporarily, it's telling stories. For epic, it's telling in a much larger plot for which we're not gonna discuss right now. For the lyrical one, it can also be divided into 4 parts: ode, elegy (/ 'elədʒi/), sonnet, and dramatic monologue. We're quite familiar to what Shakespeare wrote, right. *Sonnet* written by him is clarified within this region. For a Cambridge non-credit student, XU got a lot of time dealing with such form of Literature, just as he said, "Cambridge opens his eyes." During writing about personal feelings, I mean, a lot of his early writings are about the sceneries in Cambridge which rises his emotion up. XU had tried nearly all the types of British poetry in order to transplant them under the conditions in Chinese, either succeed or fail, he actually set a baseline to the creation of the usage of vernacular Chinese in poetry writing.

I Wandered Lonely as a Cloud — William Wordsworth, 1804

I wandered lonely as a cloud
That floats on high o'er vales and hills,
When all at once I saw a crowd,
A host, of golden daffodils;
Beside the lake, beneath the trees,
Fluttering and dancing in the breeze.

Continuous as the stars that shine
And twinkle on the milky way,
They stretched in never-ending line
Along the margin of a bay:
Ten thousand saw I at a glance,
Tossing their heads in sprightly dance.

The waves beside them danced; but they
Out-did the sparkling waves in glee:
A poet could not but be gay,
In such a jocund company:
I gazed—and gazed—but little thought
What wealth the show to me had brought:

For oft, when on my couch I lie
In vacant or in pensive mood,
They flash upon that inward eye
Which is the bliss of solitude;
And then my heart with pleasure fills,
And dances with the daffodils.

20

Here, William Wordsworth, a British poet who is really admired by XU Zhimo wrote this *I Wandered Lonely as a Cloud* in 1804. I am not a really good expert in comparative literature but the rhythm when reading has no requirements in foreign cultural understanding. The first sentence, “I wandered lonely as a cloud” has a jumping melody, which the words’ intonation rise and dive from words to words. You can try it right. This is not common, or nearly no in classical Chinese poetry. Just recap the *Blue Collar* and *Mooring on River Qinhua* we’d read just now, such fluidity is not such common used. You can say well, DU Mu’s writing contains some of it, but it only comes from the using of rhymes. However, for Wordsworth, his whole texts various in length, such variation also helps to develop the sense of poetic writing which makes the whole text melodic.

再別康橋——徐志摩，1928（民）



Second Farewell to Cambridge in Cambridge, U.K.

輕輕的我走了，
正如我輕輕的來；
我輕輕的招手，
作別西天的雲彩。
那河畔的金柳，
是夕陽中的新娘；
波光裏的艷影，
在我的心頭蕩漾。
軟泥上的青荇，
油油的在水底招搖；
在康河的柔波裏，
我甘心做一條水草！
但我不敢放歌，
悄悄是別離的笙簫；
夏蟲也為我沉默，
沉默是今晚的康橋！
悄悄的我走了，
正如我悄悄的來；
我揮一揮衣袖，
不帶走一片雲彩。
尋夢？撐一支長篙，
向青草更青處漫溯，
滿載一船星輝，
在星輝斑斕裏放歌。
揉碎在浮藻間，
沉澱着彩虹似的夢。
那榆陰下的一潭，
不是清泉，是天上虹，
揉碎在浮藻間，
沉澱着彩虹似的夢。

21

Now the famous *Second Farewell to Cambridge*, written by XU Zhimo in 1928. We'll have a look at the Chinese version first because it'll show more characteristics and comparisons better. The composition of words here is such harmonious that render the departure that silently and widely. The handshake is used to farewell the clouds around the heaven that drags the whole scene that deep and large. “輕輕的我走了，正如我輕輕的來” has a similar melodic expression in Wordsworth's writing. The syllable (/ 'sɪləb(ə)l/) is stepping but with a changing in word compound, as the third and forth line switch the words into “招手” and “作別西天的雲彩”. Moreover, for rhymes, XU doesn't make them fixed in one type but change them as the writing goes on. “來” and “彩” are ended with “ai”, but for the second verse, “娘” and “漾” are ended with “ang”. These changes in rhymes add vividity to the poem, making it flow in a dynamic motion with changes in its rhythm. Back to the classical poetry, punctuations appear every last at the end of each line that mostly are commas and full stops. However, in XU's poem, we can find a relative free switch between each line. Here, “那榆蔭下的一潭，/不是清泉，是天上虹/揉碎在浮藻間，/沉澱着彩虹似的夢。”, the transition between “虹” and “揉碎” is left blank without punctuations. This is quite abnormal to Chinese classical poetry but can trace its origins back to the British poetry we've just mentioned.

(I gazed—and gazed—but little thought/What wealth the show to me had brought:/For oft, when on my couch I lie/In vacant or in pensive mood,)

Second Farewell to Cambridge
(再別康橋)

— XU Zhimo, 1928

Quietly I am leaving,
Just as I quietly I came;
Quietly I wave goodbye
To clouds blazing the western sky.

The golden willow by the river
Is a bride at sunset;
In sparkling waves a radiant reflection
Ripples through my heart.

Waterlilies in soft mud,
Lush beckoning from deep;
In the gentle waves of River Cam
I'd rather be a waterwood!

The pool under the elm's shade
Not a spring, but a heavenly rainbow
Scattered among floating algae
Settling into a rainbow-colored dream.

Looking for a dream? Get a long pole,
Row toward the greenest of grass,
Carry a boatload of starlight,
And sing aloud in starlight's splendor.

But I cannot sing aloud,
Silence is the tune of departure;
Even summer insects stay mute for me,
Mute is tonight's Cambridge.

Silently I am leaving,
Just as silently I came;
I straighten my sleeves,
And carry not a patch of cloud.

Turning back to the English version, we can also find the words XU's using is quite symbolic. The metaphor here to describe the pool under the shadow of elm is a rainbow

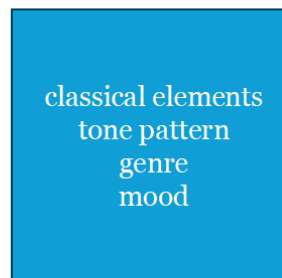
which is quite far from the tenor but provides a sense of peace and silence, as we can imagine a colorful figure lying beneath the shadow of slowly swaying leaves. Moreover, the last verse makes a recall to the first, making the whole poem under the phenomenon of departure that brings out a feeling connecting far far away to the silently separation.

Classic to Modern – A Transition

Transplant



Inherit



23

Making a comparison between XU Zhimo's writing to GUO Moruo's writing we've discussed before, even though there's a different style of writing, we can still find out some common points which lead to a transition for Chinese poetry from classical to modern. It mainly consists two parts: transplant of the western and inherit from the tradition. For transplantation, we can find out both two poets emphasize on the poet themselves as "I" appears more often than it's in classical writings. Both get their ideas of writing from western insights, which appears as the interactions between western philosophy. Lastly, the change in melody and rhythm is quite obvious, making the poems vivid in reading. For inheritance, we can still find out the pattern from the classical. From HU Shih to XU Zhimo, the characters using are not long but usually short. Still, thanks to those short lines, we can get more emotion from performing since reading becomes straighter. Moreover, the tone pattern is still in use. Poets still try to add rhymes at the end, making the texts united as a whole.

Modern/Contemporary Chinese Poetry

A Taste

24

A taste of modern and contemporary Chinese poetry.

Fragment (斷章) – BIAN Zhiling, 1935

You stand on the bridge looking at the scenery,
a person upstairs looking at the scenery watches you.
The bright moon adorns your window;
you adorn another's dream.

你站在橋上看風景，
看風景人在樓上看你。
明月裝飾了你的窗子，
你裝飾了別人的夢。

——〈斷章〉，卞之琳（民）

25

Fragment, written by BIAN Zhiling in 1935 can be considered as an extension of the style of XU Zhimo. Things that fascinate me is the linkage between the scene he created. By having a person looking at a person that is also looking, a repetitive anadiplosis (/ˌænədɪˈploʊsɪs/) is used in environment description, pretty similar to some of the writings from SHEN Congwen. Both of them restrict the plot within a single or connected surroundings, making emotions reveals within the environment exclusively.

Facing the Ocean,
Spring Warm Flowers Open
(面朝大海，春暖花开)

– Hai Zi (P.R.C.), 1989



starting from tomorrow, become a content person
feed the horses, split wood, roam the world
starting from tomorrow, I'll concern myself with grains and vegetables
I have a home, facing the ocean, spring warm flowers open

starting from tomorrow, I'll write letters to all the relatives
to tell them of my contentedness
what that content lighting flash told me
I will tell everyone

give a warm welcome to every river and every mountain
strangers, I send you my blessings
I hope for you a splendid future
I hope that you lovers become family
I hope that in this dusty world you become content
I only hope to face the ocean, as spring warm and flowers open

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Another contemporary poet, HAI Zi, his very famous *Facing the Ocean, Spring Warm Flowers Open* written in 1989, using an ordinary expression but express his own attitude towards life and death. You can have a taste of it.

Why P.O.E.M.S., still?



“But I don’t want comfort. I want God, I want poetry, I want real danger, I want freedom, I want goodness. I want sin.”

– Aldous Huxley, *Brave New World*, 1932

27

At last, I wanna talk about poetry itself as a style of Literature. Why are we still discussing poetry after all? In 1932, English writer Aldous Huxley published his dystopian novel, *Brave New World*. In the novel, he reflects the impact of technological developments onto humanity. Can people “live” under such society? He gave his answer towards the cold machine and logical formulae through conversation in novel, “But I don’t want comfort. I want God, I want poetry, I want real danger, I want freedom, I want goodness. I want sin.” Pretty much alike to what Hannah Arendt had said in her *Human Condition*, that also

Why Literature?

What is Literature?

什麼是文學？

文學：Study of *Wen*

Astronomy (天文), Hydrology (水文), Humanity (人文)

Wen is an ecological collection, containing a variety of social aspects, where social should be considered as an environment/surroundings as a whole.

28

So, before poetry, there's always Literature. Why are we still learning Literature? I mean, the major of Literature still exists till now right. What is Literature indeed? In Chinese, 文學, can be considered as a study of *Wen*, while *Wen* usually appears within different regions including Astronomy (天文), Hydrology (水文), Humanity (人文) and a lot. We can notice that *Wen* consists a group of areas which can be considered as an ecological collection, that containing a variety of social aspects, where, here, social should be considered as an environment or surroundings as a whole.

Why Literature?

As Literature, we write about humanities.

Literature：文學，文章

“Writing that applies this humanitarianism in its recordings and studies of all questions concerning human life, that is what we call humane literature...”

– ZHOU Zuoren, *Humane Literature* (Ren de Wenxue)

「用這人道主義為本，對於人生諸問題，加以記錄研究的文字，便為之人的文學。」

——周作人〈人的文學〉

29

So as for Literature, in Chinese, 文學 or simply 文章, we mainly discuss humanities. Citing from LU Xun's brother, ZHOU Zuoren in his essay *Humane Literature*, published in

1918, discussed about what Literature should write about. “Writing that applies this humanitarianism (/hjuːˌmæniˈteriənɪzəm/) in its recordings and studies of all questions concerning human life, that is what we call humane literature”. And that is what we should write and think about according to the May-forth Movement.

Why P.O.E.M.S., still?

As Literature, we write about humanities.

Literature as an art style, revealing questions and answers.
Literature as a study of humanities. (人學)

Poetry is the most concise and direct performance of Literature.
The day we stop discussing poetry will be the end of Literature for its meaning has been vanished.

30

Afterall, we can make a simplified conclusion about Literature, as we are storytellers of humanities. For me, Literature is more like an art style that revealing questions and answers, where some famous one only reveals questions but without answers, leaving a blank and freedom of imagination to the readers, making them to “think”, to “reflect”. For poetry, it’s the most concise and direct performance of Literature. At the start, I list some characteristics of poetry that all make it as the most representative for Literature itself. The day we stop discussing poetry will be the end of Literature for its meaning has been vanished. Poetry contains a unique ethnic icon, even after the Auschwitz, we still need poetry.

Why P.O.E.M.S., still?

On the Power of Mara (Satanic) Poetry

(摩羅詩力說), Lu Xun, 1908

What is a *good* Literature?

Imagination (phantasie, 想象力)

Ethnicity (Volkscharakter/Nationalcharakter, 國民性/
民族性)



Chinese *Sound* had faded away with time.

From *Books of Odes* to moderation (mittelmäßigkeit, 中庸).

31

In 1908, before the publishment of *Diary of a Madman*, LU Xun published an essay on journal *He Nan*, which is *On the Power of Mara Poetry* (摩羅詩力說). In this essay written by him in classical Chinese, he identified a genealogy of ethnic poets, according to him, the Mara Poet, or Satanic Poet. According to LU Xun, what makes a good Literature is the imagination and ethnicity, where the latter one becomes the famous “國民性” or “民族性” in Chinese. Talking about ethnicity, the sound of Chinese had faded away with time. In the beginning, we talked about *Books of Odes* right and saying that a nearly no restriction in creation to it, that make it express the most purified emotion. As time passed, Confucianist becomes the lead of people’s mind which made them less creative, making people moderate, losing the unique Chinese voice in the history. I am not saying about Confucius himself, instead, Master Cong has a great attitude towards creation like music. (琴棋書畫)

Why P.O.E.M.S., still...

Poetry is all about imagination...

A Chinesenessed imagination...

In the end, poetry is all about imagination and more accurate, the Chinese poetry shows a Chinesenessed imagination. Here I mean Chineseness is not restricted to the so called “cultural center” Mainland China, but sino-region, including Singapore, Malaysia, Taiwan, Hong Kong, Macao, or even in America for the American Chinese. After all that is what should be kept all along the time.

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